Past Wasn't Done with Me

By Kemp Powers

(Pgs 335-342) The first time that I passed out on the Chicago train, I knew I was dying from mad cow disease. At least that's what I told my doctor, and he was pretty impressed by the depths of my neurosis. But he assured me that I wasn't. I had anxiety. And he asked me if there was anything that had happened recently causing stress, and I had to think about the question.

I said, "My father's dying of cancer -- My daughter almost died last year from febrile seizures, and I'm pretty much terrified to be left alone with her." Now, this raised his eyebrows. He wrote me a prescription for Xanax and gave me the name of a therapist.

Now, I don't know what prompted me to say what I said next, but as he handed me the prescription, I blurted out: "There's one more thing: When I was 14 years old, I shot my best friend in the face accidentally, and I watched him die."

Henry was one of seven people to die that day in New

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York City, 1988. He wasn't even the youngest kid from Queens that had that dubious distinction. But his was the death that I saw with my own eyes. The one that I was responsible for with my own hands, and the one I'm going to carry with me for the rest of my life.

INTRODUCTION

Past trauma has a way of refusing to stay buried -- resurfacing when life cracks open just enough. And the truth is: surviving something doesn't mean you've escaped it; in fact, healing often begins only when we stop running from what haunts us.

The Past Wasn't Done with Me by Kemp Powers

Home back then was a 2-bedroom in Brooklyn. It was a big source of pride for my mom, who had raised my three older sisters and me since splitting from my dad when I was 4 years old. New York was really violent and dangerous back then. 2000-murders-a-year violent. But I never let the violence in the world impact me.

I was actually an honor roll student. And when Henry and I met in the 7th grade, we got along immediately. The physical contrast couldn't have been more extreme. He was unusually muscular and well-built for a 12-year-old,

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and I was just as oddly tall and lanky for a kid the same age. But that's where our differences ended. We were into all the same things. We shared all the same fears. We walked together every day after school to the Carroll Street subway station in South Brooklyn. And we both hated the older boys from John Jay High School nearby, who'd show up every Halloween and rain rotten eggs and water balloons filled with Nair on our heads, which gave you a nice surprise when you got home and tried to clean up. He was my first and best friend.

On the afternoon of April 14, 1988, Henry and Chris, another friend of mine, came by my apartment. They dropped their book bags and plopped down on my bed. My mother was a captain in the Army Reserves at this time; we had three guns in the house. The .38-caliber revolver was my favorite, not just because it was the one kept loaded. It looked like a gun from the movies, and it was the one I always showed to my friends, even though my mom never knew about it. And this day was no different.

I started off by emptying the gun, made sure all the

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bullets were out. Then I demonstrated my index finger spin-the cowboy move that I'd been working on. Then I took a single bullet, pretended to insert it into the cylinder, and pointed the gun at my friends. I can actually remember smiling as I pulled the trigger, ready to shout, "Gotcha!" when I made them jump.

But instead of the dull click of a hammer followed by laughter, there was a muzzle flash, an explosion, and shock. ***How did the bullet get into the chamber?***

Chris looked at me, and my heart started racing, and we both looked over at Henry. I guess we were waiting for him to turn around and tell me how much trouble I was gonna get into when my mother got home.

Now, whenever we're faced with something horrific, I think it's human instinct to want to run, and mentally that's what I did. Then the next thing you know the hallway was full of people.

My mom was there, sobbing. The paramedics were there. Of course, the cops were there. When one of the paramedics came out of the apartment, I remember begging him, "Please tell me he's okay, please tell me he's

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okay," and even though I knew what he was gonna say, I wasn't prepared for the words: "He's gone."

That night in the police station I had to recount in detail everything that happened. I didn't want to. I wanted to crawl under that table and hide. But I did, slowly, methodically, choking back tears when I looked down and realized my sweatshirt was covered in blood.

The wake came a week later, and I didn't think Henry's family would have any interest in me attending, but my mom insisted we go. There was a huge crowd gathered around the coffin, and I made my way over to Henry. They had him in a really nice blue suit. But I remember the coffin making him look so small. And I just stood there and stared at him. That's when I heard this woman's voice. She said, "I JUST WANT TO SEE HIM!" I didn't know whether she was talking about Henry lying there in a coffin, or me, his killer, standing over him, crying onto his jacket. Every eye in the funeral home was on me, and all I could do was close my eyes and wish that I was someplace else.

Miraculously, Henry's family did not want to press charges. They embraced me and offered their forgiveness,

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and when the Brooklyn DA hit me with a list of charges, ranging from manslaughter to assault with a deadly weapon, they were the ones who stood up and said they didn't want to destroy two young lives instead of one.

They're the reason that, instead of going to jail, I got one year of counseling. That was my sentence. I remember thanking them that day for giving me a second chance when I didn't think I deserved one.

In the years that followed, I thought it was odd that no one -- none of my friends, none of my family -- ever said a single word about Henry. Everyone went about their lives as though he had never existed. [And] the entire incident was wiped from my record when I was sixteen.

But I thought about the shooting and Henry almost every day. And oddly enough, it's what drove me for a number of years. I wouldn't touch alcohol. I wouldn't smoke a cigarette. I just felt like I had to do him proud. I had to be perfect. And for a long period of time, I thought I was doing it. Successful career. Faithful husband. Doting father to my daughter.

When my daughter got sick at eighteen months, it

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pretty much derailed all of it. We rushed her to the hospital, her body was convulsing, and all of a sudden emotions and feelings I hadn't felt since I was 14 came rushing back. The feeling of panic. . . helplessness. And that's when it dawned on me, ***Maybe this is gonna be my sentence, that I'm gonna have to see what it's like to lose a child.*** Miraculously, she did survive, but the damage was done, and when we got back home, everything was completely different. I was terrified to be left alone with her. I felt like the second it was just me and her, something was gonna go wrong.

After she got sick, a recurring dream I was having about Henry began to repeat itself with disturbing frequency. Always the same dream: I'd be asleep, I'd wake up, and he'd be sitting on the edge of my bed, staring at me, with the bullet hole still in his chin.

I'd start talking to him. I'd say, "Hey, how are you doing?" and his blank face would show no expression. After a while, I'd start pleading with him, asking him if he knew how sorry I was -- if he knew it was an accident. I'd ask him if he knew how much I missed him. Finally he

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would open his mouth and try to respond, but just like on that day, the bullet stopped him from speaking, and he gasped for air. I'd wake up crying in bed.

This dream repeated itself for years. Fourteen, eighteen, twenty-one, twenty-five, thirty. It took me passing out on the train that day to realize I needed help.

Henry is dead, and I killed him. I honestly don't believe there's any amount of good I can do in my life that'll absolve me of his death. But my trying to live a life for two people, one of whom I can never bring back, was a recipe for disaster that was gonna doom me and everyone who cared about me.

My marriage died, but I lived on. My daughter's 13 years old now and healthy. I have an 8-year-old son. I hope both grow up to be wonderful people -- the type who bring so much joy to everyone around them that their absence would be a tragedy, because that's the type of person that Henry was.

He died 24 years ago, and it's still fresh. But I'm no longer miserable. In fact, I am well on my way to becoming one of the happiest people I know, and I think

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that fact would've made him happy. He also doesn't visit me in my dreams anymore, and I can finally admit that I'm comfortable with never seeing his face ever again, in my dreams or otherwise. Because at the end of the day, what would a man like me have to say to his 14-year-old friend that hasn't been said already?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kemp Powers
Book: The Moth: 50 True Stories, Pgs 335-342
ISBN: 978-1401311117
Publisher: Hachette Books
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2013

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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